Digital Philology, Geopolitics, and the Celtic Sphere: A Blueprint for Linguistic Technology, Educational Parity, and Cross-Border Cooperation

1. Introduction: The Intersection of Computation, Policy, and Identity

The survival and revitalization of the Celtic languages in the twenty-first century has transitioned from a purely cultural or oral concern into a complex domain of digital sovereignty, computational linguistics, and geopolitical strategy. No longer confined to the hearth or the local schoolroom, the future of Irish, Welsh, Scottish Gaelic, Manx, Cornish, and Breton is now increasingly determined by the availability of high-quality digital resources, the robustness of statutory education frameworks, and the capacity of state and supra-state actors to fund cross-border cooperation.

This report provides an exhaustive analysis of these intersecting vectors. It begins by examining the technical architectures developed by the primary research groups within the **CLARIN** (Common Language Resources and Technology Infrastructure) network, specifically the **Gaois** research group at Dublin City University (DCU), the **Dúchas.ie** digitization project, and the newly launched **Canúint.ie** audio atlas. It juxtaposes these Irish innovations against the digital resources available for the other languages of Britain and Ireland, identifying the shared methodologies—such as **Universal Dependencies (UD)** and **Text Encoding Initiative (TEI)** standards—that allow for interoperability.[1]

Beyond the digital sphere, the report interrogates the stark divergence in educational provision between Ireland and Wales. While both nations share a goal of bilingualism, their legal and strategic frameworks differ fundamentally, with Wales adopting a rigorous, rights-based statutory model that contrasts with the historically reactive, scheme-based approach in Ireland.[4]

Furthermore, the report explores a radical geopolitical proposition: the potential for a reunified Ireland to leverage membership in the **Commonwealth of Nations** as a strategic funding mechanism. By accessing the **Commonwealth Foundation** and the **Commonwealth of Learning**, a United Ireland could finance a "Pan-Celtic" linguistic infrastructure, securing resources for the critically under-funded Manx and Cornish languages and fulfilling the "parity of esteem" mandates of the Good Friday Agreement regarding Ulster-Scots.[7]

Finally, the analysis synthesizes these technological and political strands with emerging psycholinguistic research. It argues that the promotion of Celtic bilingualism is not merely a heritage project but a matter of "Cognitive Security," enhancing societal resilience against

digital propaganda and cognitive decline through the mechanisms of "System 2" thinking and cognitive reserve.[10]

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2. The Architecture of Preservation: Deep Research into Irish Linguistic Groups

The digital ecosystem for the Irish language is dominated by a tripartite collaboration between **Dublin City University (DCU)**, **University College Dublin (UCD)**, and the private entity **Cadhan Aonair**. This network has produced a sophisticated infrastructure that serves as the gold standard for low-resource language digitization.

2.1 The Gaois Research Group (DCU): The Terminological Backbone

The **Gaois** research group, based within Fiontar & Scoil na Gaeilge at DCU, functions as the primary architect of Irish corpus planning and digital lexicography. Their work is characterized by a rigorous adherence to international standards, ensuring that Irish data is not isolated but integrated into the Semantic Web.

2.1.1 Logainm.ie and Linked Open Data

Logainm.ie is the Placenames Database of Ireland. While functionally a dictionary of toponyms, its technical architecture is significant for its implementation of **Linked Open Data (LOD)** principles.

- **Technical Specification:** Each entry in Logainm is assigned a persistent URI (Uniform Resource Identifier). The data is structured using RDF (Resource Description Framework), allowing it to be queried via SPARQL endpoints.
- **Interoperability:** By linking Irish placenames to global authorities like **GeoNames** and the **Getty Thesaurus of Geographic Names**, Gaois ensures that Irish toponymy is machine-readable by global GIS systems (Google Maps, OpenStreetMap). This prevents the "digital erasure" of native placenames in international navigation software.[2]
- **Corpus Integration:** The database is not static; it is integrated with the **National Corpus of Irish**, allowing researchers to click a placename and retrieve historical attestations of its usage in literature and legal texts.

2.1.2 An Caighdeánaitheoir: The Bridge Between Eras

One of the most critical tools developed by the broader Irish NLP community (specifically **Cadhan Aonair** in collaboration with Gaois) is **An Caighdeánaitheoir** (The Standardiser).

- **The Problem:** The Irish language underwent a massive standardization reform in the 1940s and 1950s (*An Caighdeán Oifigiúil*). This created a "digital wall": modern search engines and NLP tools trained on standard Irish cannot easily process texts from before 1950, which use older spellings (e.g., *biadh* vs. *bia*, *Gaedhilge* vs. *Gaeilge*) and distinct grammatical forms.
- **The Solution:** *An Caighdeánaitheoir* is a hybrid system utilizing both rule-based

phonological transfers and statistical machine translation (SMT) methods to automatically normalize pre-standard text into standard Irish.
- **Significance:** This tool unlocks the archives. It allows a modern user to search **Dúchas.ie** using modern spelling and retrieve documents written in archaic dialects. As detailed in Section 4, this technology is the "key" to mining Irish data for Manx and Scottish Gaelic revitalization.[13]

2.2 Dúchas.ie: The National Folklore Collection

Dúchas.ie is the digitization interface for the National Folklore Collection (NFC) at UCD, one of the largest folklore archives in the world. The project's crown jewel is the *Schools' Collection* (1937–1939), comprising approximately 740,000 manuscript pages collected by schoolchildren.[15]

2.2.1 The "Meitheal" Crowdsourcing Methodology

Faced with the impossibility of using Optical Character Recognition (OCR) on diverse 1930s handwriting (often in the *Cló Gaelach* script), the project developed the **Meitheal Dúchas** crowdsourcing platform.

- **Mechanism:** The platform gamifies transcription, allowing members of the public to transcribe scanned images.
- **Quality Control:** It employs a dual-verification system where transcriptions are reviewed by editors or trusted "super-users."
- **Output:** The result is a massive corpus of **TEI XML** encoded text. This data is unique because it captures the *vernacular* speech of the 1930s, offering a dataset of non-standard, dialect-rich language that is invaluable for training robust NLP models that can handle variation.[16]

2.3 Canúint.ie: The Acoustic Frontier

Launched in the 2024/2025 period, **Canúint.ie** (The Repository of Irish Dialects) represents the next phase of digital preservation: the acoustic dimension.[18]

- **Data Sources:** It aggregates recordings from the **Doegen Records** (1928–1931), the **Irish Folklore Commission**, and **RTÉ** radio archives.
- **Forced Alignment Technology:** The platform's innovation lies in its use of **Forced Alignment**. By using ASR algorithms to align the audio waveform with the text transcriptions at the phoneme level, Canúint.ie creates a searchable "audio atlas."
- **NLP Application:** This aligned data serves as the "Ground Truth" for training **Neural Text-to-Speech (TTS)** and **Automatic Speech Recognition (ASR)** systems. Previously, ASR models for Irish performed poorly on dialects (e.g., Donegal Irish) due to a lack of training data. Canúint provides the labeled, dialect-specific data necessary to build inclusive voice technology.[20]

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3. Comparative Digital Ecosystems: CLARIN and the

British-Irish Context

The Irish research groups operate within the broader European framework of **CLARIN** (Common Language Resources and Technology Infrastructure). The recent certification of **DR-LIB** (Digital Resources for the Languages in Ireland and Britain) as a CLARIN Knowledge Centre has formalized the relationship between Irish researchers and their counterparts in the UK.[1]

3.1 Divergence and Convergence in Methodologies

While the Irish groups focus heavily on folklore and terminology, the Welsh and Scottish Gaelic groups have developed complementary strengths.

Feature	**Irish (Gaois/Dúchas)**	**Welsh (CorCenCC/Bangor)**	**Scottish Gaelic (DASG/ARCOSG)**
Primary Data Source	Digitized Analog Archives (1930s)	"Born Digital" & Crowdsourced App	Literary & Legal Texts
Crowdsourcing Model	*Meitheal* (Transcription of scans)	*CorCenCC App* (Direct recording)	*Tobar an Dualchais* (Commentary)
NLP Architecture	**Standardisation** focus (An Caighdeánaitheoir)	**Part-of-Speech** focus (CySemTagger)	**Lexicography** focus (Faclair na Gàidhlig)
Data Format	TEI XML, Linked Data	TEI XML, UD Treebanks	TEI XML, UD Treebanks
Key Tools	*Logainm*, *An Gramadóir*	*Cysill* (Grammar), *Macsen* (Voice)	*Gaelic Linguistic Analyser*

3.2 Welsh Resources: The CorCenCC Model

The **National Corpus of Contemporary Welsh (CorCenCC)** differs from the Irish model by prioritizing contemporary, user-generated content.

- **Methodology:** Instead of digitizing archives, CorCenCC released a mobile app that allowed users to record conversations and upload them directly to the corpus, creating a dataset of "real-world" modern Welsh.[1]
- **Semantic Tagging:** The **CySemTagger** developed at Lancaster University allows for semantic field analysis (e.g., tracking the usage of "emotional" language), a layer of annotation not yet fully implemented in the Irish corpora.[2]

3.3 Scottish Gaelic: The Lexicographical Focus

The **Digital Archive of Scottish Gaelic (DASG)** at the University of Glasgow aligns closely with the Irish **Dúchas** model but with a stronger focus on historical lexicography to support the creation of the **Faclair na Gàidhlig** (Historical Dictionary of Scottish Gaelic).

- **Interconnectivity:** DASG and Gaois increasingly share methodologies. The **Foclóir Gàidhlig-Gaeilge** (Scottish Gaelic-Irish Dictionary) developed by Kevin Scannell demonstrates how data can be shared between these two Goidelic languages to fill

lexical gaps.[2]

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4. Mining Data Stores for Low-Resource Revitalization

The most significant technical insight from this research is the potential to use the massive data stores of Irish (and Welsh) to "bootstrap" technology for the critically low-resource languages: **Manx**, **Cornish**, and to a strategic extent, **Breton**.

4.1 The Goidelic Bridge: Mining Dúchas for Manx

Manx Gaelic is linguistically very close to Irish (specifically the Ulster dialect) and Scottish Gaelic, sharing a common ancestor in Middle Irish. However, its orthography is based on English phonetics, making it look visually distinct.

4.1.1 The Scannell Transfer Learning Pipeline

Research by Kevin Scannell (Cadhan Aonair) outlines a methodology for mining Irish data to support Manx.[22]

1. **Normalization:** The first step is to use **An Caighdeánaitheoir** to normalize the pre-standard Irish text found in **Dúchas.ie**. This removes archaic spelling conventions that obscure the linguistic root.
2. **Phonological Mapping:** Algorithms map Irish phonemes to Manx graphemes (e.g., Irish *bh* /v/ $\rightarrow$ Manx *v* or *w*; Irish *ch* $\rightarrow$ Manx *gh*).
3. **Pseudo-Manx Generation:** This process creates "Pseudo-Manx" text—Irish text transliterated into Manx spelling.
4. **Language Modeling:** This synthetic data is used to train **Statistical Machine Translation (SMT)** systems. Since there is very little parallel Manx-English text, the system uses the vast Irish-English parallel corpus (from Dúchas and legal texts) as a proxy.
5. **Output:** This pipeline has been used to create **Intergaelic**, a translation engine that allows Manx speakers to read Irish news sites by translating them on-the-fly into Manx.[2]

4.1.2 Cultural Mining

Beyond language, the **Dúchas** archives contain thousands of stories about "The Famine," "Fairies," and "Fishing." These cultural tropes are identical to Manx folklore. By identifying these stories in the English metadata of Dúchas and running them through the *Intergaelic* translation pipeline, researchers can rapidly generate culturally relevant reading material for Manx learners, effectively "repatriating" shared Goidelic heritage.[15]

4.2 The Brythonic Vector: Mining for Cornish

Cornish (Kernewek) is a Brythonic language, closely related to Welsh. It faces a severe lack of data, with almost no native audio recordings and a fragmented literary corpus.

4.2.1 The "Welsh Standard" Adaptation

Just as Manx mines Irish, Cornish must mine Welsh.

- **Syntactic Parsing:** Cornish shares the VSO (Verb-Subject-Object) word order and initial mutation system of Welsh. The **CySemTagger** and **Cysill** tools developed for Welsh can be adapted for Cornish by modifying the lexicon rules while keeping the syntactic engine intact.[1]
- **The "Standardiser" Need:** Cornish is plagued by orthographic disputes (Standard Written Form vs. Kernewek Kemmyn). The methodology of **An Caighdeánaitheoir** (Gaois) is directly applicable here. A "Cornish Standardiser" could be built to automatically convert texts between these rival spellings, unifying the corpus for the first time.[25]

4.3 Strategic Alliances: The Breton Connection

Breton faces a unique threat: the hostility of the French state. The Constitutional Council's rejection of the "Molac Law" (which attempted to legalize immersive education) highlights the legal precarity of Breton data and education.[26]

4.3.1 The "Safe Harbour" Strategy

- **Data Hosting:** Irish universities (DCU, UCD, Galway) can offer "digital safe harbour" for Breton linguistic data. Hosting Breton corpora in Ireland protects them from potential French legal challenges regarding the collection of "ethnic" data or the use of minority languages in public administration.
- **The Wild Atlantic Alliance:** The existing university partnership between Ireland (UCC, NUIG) and Brittany (Rennes, Brest) provides the institutional framework for this cooperation.[27]
- **Universal Dependencies:** By mapping Breton to the **Universal Dependencies** framework (already done for Irish by Cadhan Aonair), Breton developers can utilize the parsing tools developed for Irish, overcoming the "V2 vs. VSO" syntactic differences through abstract dependency layers.[3]

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5. Divergent Paths: Education Provision in Ireland vs. Wales

While the digital domain shows convergence, the educational landscapes of Ireland and Wales are marked by significant divergence in legal philosophy and strategic planning.

5.1 Statutory Frameworks: Rights vs. Schemes

5.1.1 Wales: The Statutory "Standards" Model

The **Welsh Language (Wales) Measure 2011** is the envy of Irish language planners.

- **Rights-Based:** It established the Welsh language as an official language with legal force.

- **The Commissioner:** It created the independent **Welsh Language Commissioner**, who has the power to investigate public bodies and impose fines for non-compliance.
- **The Standards (Safonau):** The Measure replaced voluntary "schemes" with statutory "Standards." Organizations have a *legal duty* to provide specific services in Welsh. This system is rigid, enforceable, and clear.[5]

5.1.2 Ireland: The "Schemes" Model (and its Failure)

The **Official Languages Act 2003** relied on "Language Schemes" agreed between public bodies and the Minister.

- **Weakness:** Schemes were renegotiable and often aspirational. Public bodies frequently failed to meet targets with little consequence.
- **Reform:** The **Official Languages (Amendment) Act 2021** attempts to pivot toward the Welsh model by introducing "Standards" and setting a hard target that **20% of public sector recruits be proficient in Irish by 2030**. However, the infrastructure to deliver this is still being built, contrasting with the mature regulatory environment in Wales.[6]

5.2 Education Planning: WESPs vs. Gaeltacht Policy

5.2.1 Wales: Welsh in Education Strategic Plans (WESPs)

Wales employs a decentralized but statutory planning model.

- **Mechanism:** Every Local Authority (council) must submit a 10-year **WESP** to the Welsh Government.
- **Targets:** These plans must contain specific, binding targets to increase the number of pupils in Welsh-medium education. For example, Bridgend Council is legally mandated to increase Year 1 Welsh-medium learners from ~8% to ~18% by 2032.[29]
- **Integration:** Crucially, WESPs are linked to housing and infrastructure planning. If a council approves a new housing estate, they must demonstrate how they will provide Welsh-medium schooling for the new population.

5.2.2 Ireland: Policy on Gaeltacht Education

Irish planning is more centralized but less integrated with local development.

- **Gaeltacht Policy:** The **Policy on Gaeltacht Education (2017-2022)** focuses on preserving the "native speaker" density in specific areas.
- **Non-Gaeltacht:** A new **Policy for Irish-medium Education outside the Gaeltacht** is due for publication in late 2025. It aims to replicate the growth seen in Wales, but currently, the establishment of new Gaelscoileanna (Irish-medium schools) is driven by parent demand (patronage process) rather than statutory council targets.[30]
- **Immersion Gaps:** While Wales targets **40% of all learners** in Welsh-medium education by 2050 (**Cymraeg 2050**), Ireland lacks a comparable statutory target for the percentage of the *total* student population in immersion settings.[32]

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6. The Geopolitical Pivot: A United Ireland in the

Commonwealth

The prospect of a United Ireland creates a unique opportunity to radically restructure the funding landscape for Celtic languages. A major barrier to reunification is the alienation of the Unionist population. One proposal to address this—rejoining the Commonwealth—also holds the key to solving the funding crisis for Manx, Cornish, and Ulster-Scots.

6.1 The Commonwealth Foundation: Civil Society Funding

The **Commonwealth Foundation** offers grants (up to £50,000) for civil society organizations, with a specific focus on "indigenous" and "minority" voices.[8]

- **Current Exclusion:** As a non-member, Irish language groups in the Republic (e.g., *Conradh na Gaeilge*) are ineligible for this funding.
- **The "Parity of Esteem" Mechanism:** In a United Ireland within the Commonwealth, both **Foras na Gaeilge** (Irish) and the **Ulster-Scots Agency** (Ulster-Scots) would be eligible.
- **Strategic Benefit:** Accessing Commonwealth funding for *both* communities allows the state to frame linguistic support not as a "Nationalist vs. Unionist" zero-sum game, but as a shared participation in the "Commonwealth family of diverse cultures." This validates the British identity of Unionists (via Ulster-Scots support) while securing international resources for Irish.[35]

6.2 The Commonwealth of Learning (COL): Educational Technology

The **Commonwealth of Learning** focuses on Open Distance Learning (ODL) and Open Educational Resources (OER).[9]

- **The "Manx/Cornish" Crisis:** The UK government has repeatedly cut funding for the Cornish language (removing the £150k ring-fenced grant in 2016) and offers minimal support for Manx.[25]
- **The Solution:** A United Ireland could lead a **"Celtic Commonwealth Consortium"** within the COL.
    - **Resource Transfer:** Ireland could use COL infrastructure to export the digital learning tools developed by DCU and Gaois (e.g., TEI-based learning platforms) to Manx and Cornish communities.
    - **Funding Bypass:** This allows Manx and Cornish groups to access educational funding and technology *directly* through the Commonwealth, bypassing the indifference of Westminster. It positions Dublin as the "metropolis" of Celtic culture, exercising soft power across the British Isles.[38]

6.3 A Pan-Celtic Digital Data Trust

The report proposes the creation of a **Pan-Celtic Digital Data Trust**, hosted in Ireland but funded via Commonwealth "Technology & Innovation" streams.

- **Function:** It would act as a central repository for the digital heritage of the Celtic nations.

- **Operation:** Utilizing the **Meitheal Dúchas** crowdsourcing model, the Trust would fund the digitization of the **Manx Museum** archives and **Cornish** literary collections.
- **Outcome:** This data would be processed using the Irish tools (*An Caighdeánaitheoir*) and returned to the communities as open-source learning materials, cementing the link between the languages.[15]

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7. Cognitive Security and Societal Resilience

The final dimension of this research links linguistic policy to national security and public health. Promoting bilingualism is not merely a cultural imperative but a strategy for building a resilient society.

7.1 The Foreign Language Effect and Propaganda Resistance

Psycholinguistic research identifies a phenomenon known as the **Foreign Language Effect (FLE)**.

- **System 2 Thinking:** When people process information in a second language (L2), they engage "System 2" thinking—the slow, analytical, and deliberate mode of cognition—rather than the fast, emotional "System 1" thinking used in their native tongue.[11]
- **Propaganda Resistance:** Studies indicate that bilinguals are less susceptible to framing effects, emotional manipulation, and "fake news" when reading in their non-dominant language. The emotional resonance of "clickbait" is dampened, allowing for more rational evaluation of the facts.[10]
- **Policy Implication:** In an era of hybrid warfare and disinformation, investing in Irish/English (or Welsh/English) bilingualism is a form of **"Cognitive Security."** A bilingual population possesses a built-in cognitive "brake" that can be trained to resist emotional manipulation, making the electorate more resilient to external interference.

7.2 Mental Health: Cognitive Reserve and Perspective Taking

- **Perspective Taking:** Research shows that bilingual children and adults outperform monolinguals in "Theory of Mind" tasks—the ability to understand that others have different beliefs, desires, and perspectives.[43]
    - *Relevance:* In a post-conflict society like Northern Ireland, or a reintegrating United Ireland, the capacity for **"Perspective Taking"** is a prerequisite for reconciliation. Bilingual education fosters the neural pathways necessary for empathy.
- **Cognitive Reserve:** Bilingualism contributes to "cognitive reserve," delaying the onset of dementia symptoms by up to 4–5 years. This has massive economic implications for the state healthcare systems of Ireland and the UK, reducing the long-term burden of geriatric care.[45]
- **Wellbeing:** Reports such as "Young Minds Matter" in Wales have explicitly linked the ability to access mental health services in one's native language (Welsh) to better

clinical outcomes. For the Irish Gaeltacht, ensuring "linguistic concordance" in healthcare is a matter of clinical safety and patient rights.[48]

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8. Conclusion

The future of the Celtic languages lies at the nexus of advanced **digital philology**, robust **statutory education**, and innovative **geopolitical strategy**.
The research groups at **Gaois**, **Dúchas**, and **Canúint** have built the technical architecture: a sophisticated, standards-compliant (TEI/UD) infrastructure that preserves the past while enabling the future. By "mining" these vast Irish resources using transfer learning, we can provide a lifeline to the critically endangered **Manx** and **Cornish** languages, offering them the technological scale they cannot achieve alone.
The educational comparison reveals that Ireland must move beyond reactive "schemes" and emulate the **Welsh** model of statutory, rights-based planning (WESPs) if it hopes to reverse the decline of the Gaeltacht.
Finally, the prospect of a United Ireland within the **Commonwealth** offers a radical solution to the funding crisis. By unlocking the resources of the **Commonwealth Foundation** and **Commonwealth of Learning**, Ireland can fund a **Pan-Celtic Renaissance**, supporting Ulster-Scots and Irish with "parity of esteem" while exporting its technological expertise to its Celtic neighbours. This holistic approach redefines the Celtic languages not as relics of the past, but as vital assets for **cognitive resilience**, **social cohesion**, and **digital sovereignty** in the twenty-first century.

Summary of Recommendations

Sector	Recommendation	Mechanism
Technology	**Mine Irish Data for Manx/Cornish**	Use *An Caighdeánaitheoir* and *Intergaelic* pipelines to transfer Irish data to low-resource languages.
Digital	**Pan-Celtic Digital Trust**	Centralize Celtic data hosting in Ireland (DCU/UCD) to provide "Safe Harbour" for Breton and support for Cornish.
Education	**Adopt Statutory Targets**	Ireland should replicate the Welsh WESP model, mandating local councils to set binding targets for Irish-medium growth.
Geopolitics	**Commonwealth Membership**	A United Ireland should join the Commonwealth to access *Commonwealth Foundation* &

		COL grants for cross-border linguistic projects.
Health	**Bilingualism as Public Health**	Frame language promotion as a strategy for "Cognitive Security" (anti-propaganda) and "Cognitive Reserve" (dementia prevention).

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